



from the press area," I imagined him saying. During the changeover, the officer came over and whispered, "I am a Messi fan".

The Diary is not a dog hater. But it is no dog lover either. It simply fears dogs and would rather not have them in any public space without a leash. During the Diary's childhood, a dog had chased it into a stormwater drain. Childhood scars last long, really long. So when it learnt that Wimbledon does not allow players to bring dogs to the grounds for fear that they would damage the grass, it was quietly pleased. At the All England Club, there is a place only for security dogs and no other canines.

But women's World No. 1 Aryna Sabalenka did not agree with the policy.

"I can understand why they made this decision," she said after her second-round victory. "If the dog does something wrong inside this historical place, it's probably going to take a bit of time to replace. They're probably afraid of damage inside. But I have to say all of our dogs are very well trained. It just sometimes hurts to leave him at the house by himself.

It really hurts my feelings. It's just like a little fluffy thing that always wants cuddles and love. Going to the park with him, walking around, is also like meditation for me. Wimbledon, please, I beg you, let the dogs inside."

A few pleas went even further. On *Tennis Channel*, Martina Navratilova's dog was introduced as someone who had been on the Tour for more years than Stan Wawrinka. Navratilova, by virtue of being a member of the All England Club, said she would urge the authorities to change the rule. But Wimbledon does not budge easily, and that suits the Diary just fine.

This is the third straight year the Diary has been at Wimbledon. Coming from India, a developing country, it has to fill out a long and detailed visa application every year. It knows the pain because, after all that labour, it gets a visa valid for only six months. **The United States of America, the European Union countries and the United Kingdom have formed a cosy club and eased visa rules for one another.**

But when the Diary learnt that even a man as big as Alexander

Canine clause: No four-legged spectators here. Wimbledon permits only service and search dogs inside the All England Club grounds. AFP

Zverev — in stature — was having trouble procuring a visa for his grandmother, it was left perplexed. Zverev is German but of Russian origin, and only when the reigning French Open champion explained that his grandmother still held a Russian passport did the Diary put two and two together.

"She doesn't have a visa and unfortunately has a Russian passport," Zverev said when he was asked if his granny would come to watch his final versus Jannik Sinner. "I know that our Chancellor is coming for the final. Maybe, he can help with a longer visa for her, and then she can stay a bit longer. But she had to go back after 90 days."

For a fleeting second, the Diary was happy to know that it had a visa that lasted 90 days longer than Zverev's granny's. But it quickly admonished itself and silently expressed its solidarity with the aged woman.